National
Qualifications
2026

# 2026 English

# Literary Study

# Advanced Higher

# Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions

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**General marking principles for Advanced Higher English — Literary Study**

*Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.*

**(a)** Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

**(b)** If a candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions, and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

**Marking instructions for each question**

The marking instructions indicate the essential idea that a candidate should provide for each answer. Candidates gain marks for their knowledge, understanding, analysis and evaluation of the texts selected for the question.

- First read the essay to establish whether it achieves minimum requirements for technical accuracy, and whether it is relevant to the question. There may be a few errors, but they should not impede understanding. If the essay does not achieve minimum standards, award a maximum of 9 marks. Award up to full marks where the essay communicates clearly at first reading.
- Assessment should be holistic. There are strengths and weaknesses in every piece of writing. Focus as far as possible on the strengths, taking account of weaknesses only when they significantly detract from the overall performance. The literary study does not need to be perfect to gain full marks.
- Candidates may display ability across more than one band descriptor. It is important to recognise the closeness of the band descriptors and consider carefully the most appropriate overall band for the candidate's performance.

Once that best fit is decided:

- where the candidate's response fully meets the standard described, award the highest available mark from that band range
- where the candidate's response just meets the standard described, award the lowest mark from that band range
- otherwise, award the mark from the middle of the band range.



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**Marking instructions for all questions**

| | Marks 20-19 | Marks 18-16 | Marks 15-13 | Marks 12-10 | Marks 9-6 | Marks 5-0 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Knowledge and understanding**<br><br>The literary study demonstrates: | • **Comprehensive** knowledge and understanding of the texts<br>• A **full and relevant** exploration with **sustained** consideration of the implications of the question<br>• **Extensive** use of textual evidence to **support** an argument which is **clearly focused** on the demands of the question | • **Secure** knowledge and understanding of the texts<br>• A **relevant** exploration which demonstrates **secure** consideration of the implications of the question<br>• **Extensive** use of textual evidence which **clearly supports** the demands of the question | • **Broad** knowledge and understanding of the texts<br>• A **relevant and thoughtful** approach to the question<br>• Use of textual evidence which is **relevant to the demands of the question** | • Knowledge and understanding of the texts<br>• A **relevant** approach to the question<br>• Use of textual evidence to **address the demands of the question** | • **Limited** knowledge and understanding of the texts<br>• A **limited** approach to the question<br>• **Limited** textual evidence to support the demands of the question | • **Very** little knowledge of the texts<br>• **Very little** attempt to answer the question<br>• **Very little** textual evidence |
| **Analysis**<br><br>The literary study demonstrates: | • **Relevant analysis** of a task - appropriate range of literary techniques and/or features of language which **skilfully strengthens** the line of argument | • **Relevant analysis** of a task - appropriate range of literary techniques and/or features of language which **strengthens** the line of argument | • **Relevant analysis** of a range of literary techniques and/or features of language which **supports** the line of argument | • Analysis of a range of literary techniques and/or features of language | • **Limited analysis** of literary techniques and/or features of language | • **Very little analysis** of literary techniques and/or features of language |



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| | Marks 20-19 | Marks 18-16 | Marks 15-13 | Marks 12-10 | Marks 9-6 | Marks 5-0 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Evaluation**<br><br>The literary study demonstrates: | • A **committed**, **clear** evaluative stance with respect to the texts and the question, and **skilfully based on precise evidence** discussed within the response | • A **clearly identifiable** evaluative stance with respect to the texts and the question and **securely based on evidence** discussed within the response | • A **discernible and relevant** evaluative stance with respect to the texts and the question and based on evidence discussed within the response | • An evaluative stance with respect to the texts and the question but **may demonstrate some weakness in relevance** | • **Limited evaluation** with respect to the texts and/or lacks relevance to the question and/or evidence | • **Very little evidence of evaluation** and/or supporting evidence |
| **Technical accuracy**<br><br>The literary study demonstrates: | • At least **minimum competence** for technical accuracy which includes few errors in the use of structure, style, language and/or literary terminology | | | | • **Significant errors** in structure, style, language and/or literary terminology | |

**[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]**



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# Textual Analysis

# Advanced Higher

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**General marking principles for Advanced Higher English — Textual Analysis**

*Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.*

**(a)** Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

**(b)** If a candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions, and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

**Marking instructions for each question**

The marking instructions indicate the essential idea that a candidate should provide for each answer. Candidates gain marks for their knowledge, understanding, analysis and evaluation of the chosen extract.

- Assessment should be holistic. There are strengths and weaknesses in every piece of writing. Focus as far as possible on the strengths, taking account of weaknesses only when they significantly detract from the overall performance. A piece does not have to be perfect to be awarded full marks.

- Candidates may display ability across more than one band descriptor. It is important to recognise the closeness of the band descriptors and consider carefully the most appropriate overall band for the candidate's performance.

Once that best fit is decided:

- where the candidate's response fully meets the standard described, award the highest available mark from that band range
- where the candidate's response just meets the standard described, award the lowest mark from that band range
- otherwise, award the mark from the middle of the range.



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**Marking instructions for all questions**

| | Marks 20-19 | Marks 18-16 | Marks 15-13 | Marks 12-10 | Marks 9-6 | Marks 5-0 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Understanding**<br><br>The textual analysis demonstrates: | • **Comprehensive understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• A **full and relevant** exploration with **sustained** consideration of the implications of the question<br>• **Extensive** use of textual evidence to **support** an argument which is **clearly focused** on the demands of the question | • **Secure understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• A **relevant exploration** which demonstrates **secure** consideration of the implications of the question<br>• **Extensive** use of textual evidence which clearly **supports** the demands of the question | • **Broad understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• A **relevant and thoughtful** approach to the question<br>• Use of textual evidence which is **relevant** to the demands of the question | • **Understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• A **relevant approach** to the question<br>• Use of textual evidence to **address the demands** of the question | • **Limited understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• A **limited approach** to the question<br>• **Limited textual evidence** to support the demands of the question | • **Very little understanding** of the central concerns of the text provided<br>• **Very little** attempt to answer the question<br>• **Very little** textual evidence |



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| | Marks 20-19 | Marks 18-16 | Marks 15-13 | Marks 12-10 | Marks 9-6 | Marks 5-0 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Analysis**<br><br>The textual analysis demonstrates: | • **Relevant analysis** of a **task-appropriate range** of literary techniques and/or features of language which **skilfully strengthens** the approach adopted by the candidate | • **Relevant analysis** of a **task-appropriate range** of literary techniques and/or features which **strengthens the approach** adopted by the candidate | • **Relevant analysis** of a **range** of literary techniques and/or features of language which **supports** the approach adopted by the candidate | • Analysis of a **range** of literary techniques and/or features of language | • **Limited analysis** of literary techniques and/or features of language | • **Very little analysis** of literary techniques and/or features of language |
| **Evaluation**<br><br>The textual analysis demonstrates: | • A **committed**, **clear**, evaluative stance with respect to the text provided and the question, and **skilfully based on precise evidence** discussed within the response | • A **clearly identifiable** evaluative stance with respect to the text provided and the question, and **securely based on evidence** discussed within the response | • A **discernible and relevant** evaluative stance with respect to the text provided and the question, and **based on evidence** discussed within the response | • An **evaluative stance** with respect to the text provided and the question but **may be based on previously undiscussed** evidence or demonstrate some **weakness in relevance** | • **Limited evaluation** with respect to the text provided and/or **lacks relevance** to the question and/or **evidence** | • **Very little** evidence of evaluation and/or supporting evidence |

**[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]**